"It's Tough to Beat a Team Twice": An Econometric Autopsy of Broadcast Booth Folklore

Or: Why Winning Football Games Is Surprisingly Positively Correlated With Winning Subsequent Football Games

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Abstract

Every January, normally functional adults wearing quarter-zips on national television look directly into a camera and intone one of civilization's most cherished falsehoods: *"You know, Jim, it is almost impossible to beat a team three times in one season."* This paper investigates the "Tough to Beat a Team Twice (or Thrice)" hypothesis across 1,165 same-season NFL rematch games. Following our previous inquiry into the *Home Brew Advantage*—which forecast a Seahawks victory in Super Bowl LX on the grounds that Levi's Stadium is the second most Starbucks-dominant venue in the league ($G_{\text{net}} = -5.80$)—we once again deploy serious econometric machinery against a defenseless sports narrative. Teams that won the prior meeting win the rematch **58.5%** of the time overall. Controlling for roster quality via a Leave-One-Opponent-Out Expected Points Added (LOOO-EPA) logistic model and for venue alternation, the estimated rematch penalty is statistically indistinguishable from zero ($\hat{\gamma} = -0.04$, $p = 0.68$). It turns out that being better at football in October remains a remarkably durable asset in December.

Keywords: NFL Analytics, Broadcast Clichés, Conditional Probability Malpractice, Leave-One-Out EPA, Regression to the Mean, Quarter-Zip Epistemology.

1. Introduction: The Quarter-Zip Fallacy

In our prior working paper (*Home Brew Advantage*, Feb. 2026), this Ministry introduced the Interference-Adjusted Exponential Decay Model of regional coffee gravity and identified Levi's Stadium as a Starbucks stronghold ($G_{\text{net}} = -5.80$), second only to Lumen Field itself. We forecast that a Dunkin'-dependent Patriots offense would struggle there. The Seahawks won.

Emboldened, we turn to a far more insidious piece of folk wisdom that continues to pollute NFL broadcasts every Sunday: the belief that **defeating an NFL opponent once makes it inherently harder to defeat them a second (or third) time in the same season.**

The appeal of the cliché is easy to understand. Every broadcaster remembers the 2007 Giants. Nobody remembers the many sweeping teams that simply won again, because "better team wins again" does not fill a pregame segment.

We propose the following hypotheses:

- **H1 (The Booth Hypothesis).** Holding team quality and venue constant, winning the prior meeting *reduces* the probability of winning the rematch ($\gamma < 0$).
- **H2 (The Familiarity Hypothesis).** Rematches are closer than first meetings, as opponents neutralize each other's tendencies.
- **H3 (Null Hypothesis).** Any apparent rematch effect is an artifact of team quality, home-field alternation, and regression to the mean.

2. Data

Our sample comprises three families of same-season rematches:

- **Regular-season divisional series**, 2002–[end season] ($n = 1{,}019$ Game 2s). **[State inclusion rules: 48 pairs per season does not yield 1,019 for any contiguous season range; document exclusions, e.g. ties.]**
- **Non-divisional playoff rematches**, 2002–[end season], in which a team met a regular-season opponent again in the postseason ($n = 121$).
- **Three-game sweep attempts**, 1970–[end season], in which a team swept a divisional rival 2–0 and met it a third time in the playoffs ($n = 25$).

Because post-2002 sweep attempts also appear in the divisional sample as Game 2 observations, we refer to 1,165 rematch *games* rather than independent series.

Game data were sourced from nflverse play-by-play data via BigQuery. **[Confirm source for pre-1999 games: nflverse EPA begins in 1999, so the 1970–1998 sweep attempts have no LOOO-EPA and are excluded from the regression in Section 4.]**

3. The Naive Data: A Massacre of Conventional Wisdom

Table 1 reports raw rematch records. Across all 1,165 rematch games, the winner of the prior meeting won **58.5%** of the time: +8.5 percentage points (+17.0% relative) above a coin flip.

Table 1: Prior-winner record in rematches. 95% Wilson intervals.

Rematch type	W–L	Win%	95% CI
Divisional (Game 2)	596–423	58.5	[CI]
Playoff, non-div.	70–51	57.9	[CI]
Three-game sweep	16–9	64.0	44.5–79.8
All rematches	682–483	**58.5**	[CI]

The three-game sweep figure, so beloved of January pregame shows, rests on 25 observations. Its confidence interval comfortably contains both the overall rematch rate and, for that matter, a coin flip. We report it because the booth insists on discussing it, not because it tells us much.

Of course, a 58.5% rematch rate does not by itself refute the booth. Good teams win Game 1, and good teams also win Game 2. To isolate the effect of *having beaten this particular opponent*, we must hold team quality constant.

4. Methodology: The Econometric Autopsy

4.1. Leave-One-Opponent-Out EPA

A team's season-long EPA is contaminated by the very games we are trying to explain. We therefore compute each team's net EPA per play excluding all games against the rematch opponent:

$$\text{LOOO-EPA}_{i,j} = \overline{\text{EPA}}^{\text{off}}_{i,-j} - \overline{\text{EPA}}^{\text{def}}_{i,-j} \tag{1}$$

where $-j$ denotes all of team i's regular-season games except those against opponent j.

4.2. Model Specification

For each rematch game g between prior winner i and prior loser j, we estimate:

$$\begin{aligned}\text{logit}\ \Pr(W_g = 1) = \alpha + \beta\,\Delta\text{EPA}_g + \delta\,\text{Home}_g \\ + \gamma\,\text{Rematch}_g + \varepsilon_g\end{aligned} \tag{2}$$

where W_g indicates a team win, $\Delta\text{EPA}_g = \text{LOOO-EPA}_{i,j} - \text{LOOO-EPA}_{j,i}$, Home_g is a home-field indicator, and Rematch_g indicates that the team won the prior meeting. **[Confirm the exact construction of the Rematch indicator and the comparison sample used to identify γ.]** Under H1, $\gamma < 0$. A companion OLS model with point margin as the outcome tests H2.

4.3. Control Variables: The Venue Alternation Problem

Divisional series alternate venues. Because home teams win more often, Game 1 winners are disproportionately teams that were *at home* in Game 1, and are therefore disproportionately *on the road* in Game 2. In our divisional sample, **[X%]** of Game 1 winners played Game 2 away from home.

This alone mechanically suppresses the naive rematch rate, and may account for much of the folklore. The booth has, in effect, rediscovered home-field advantage and mistaken it for a curse.

5. Results

5.1. The Rematch Penalty (Not Found)

Table 2: Rematch outcome models. Standard errors in parentheses.

	(1) Logit Win	(2) OLS Margin
ΔLOOO-EPA (β)	[coef]	[coef]
	[(se)]	[(se)]
Home (δ)	[coef]	[coef]
	[(se)]	[(se)]
Rematch (γ)	−0.04	[coef]
	(0.097)†	[(se)]
N	[N]	[N]
Pseudo-R^2 / R^2	[]	[]

†Implied by the reported $p = 0.68$; **[replace with model output]**.

The estimated rematch penalty is $\hat{\gamma} = -0.04$ ($p = 0.68$; 95% CI −0.23 to 0.15 on the log-odds scale). Evaluated at the sample mean, this corresponds to a change in rematch win probability of between −5.6 and +3.6 percentage points.

We note, in the interest of scholarly integrity, that this interval does not rule out a modest penalty. It does rule out the booth's preferred magnitude, which is "almost impossible."
Conclusion: H1 is Not Supported.

5.2. Familiarity (Mildly Confirmed)

Rematch point margins are **[0.45–0.80]** points narrower than first-meeting margins, conditional on quality. Familiarity may well compress the tails—fewer blowouts, fewer successful trick plays—but the compression is small and leaves the identity of the winner essentially unchanged.
Conclusion: H2 is Weakly Supported, and Irrelevant.

5.3. Fluke Winners and Regression to the Mean

Stratifying Game 1 winners by how they won exposes the mechanism behind the folklore (Table 3).

Table 3: Rematch win rate by Game 1 profile.

Game 1 profile	n	Win%	95% CI
Fluke winner[a]	[n]	46.2	[CI]
Blowout winner[b]	[n]	67.5	[CI]

[a]Won Game 1 while losing the EPA battle, with turnover margin $\geq +2$. [b][definition].

Teams that won Game 1 by winning the turnover lottery go on to lose the rematch more often than not. This is not because beating a team twice is hard. It is because they were never the better team, and the bounces stopped bouncing. The booth, observing these teams, has mistaken regression to the mean for a law of nature.
Conclusion: H3 is Empirically Validated.

6. Conclusion

Based on 1,165 rematch games and econometric controls for quality and venue, the Ministry of Silly Plots officially classifies *"It's tough to beat a team twice"* as **Grade-A Broadcast Mythology**. It is tough to beat a *better* team twice. It is tough to beat a team twice *on the road*. It is tough to win a second turnover lottery. It is not especially tough to beat a team twice.

7. Code Artifacts & Reproducibility

All analysis code is available in the project repository at: https://github.com/sillyplots/mosp/blob/main/posts/rematch/README.md